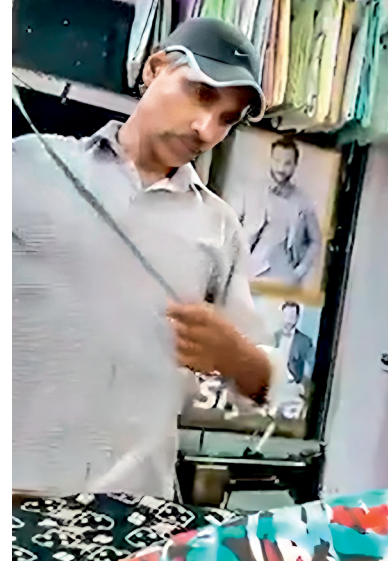
on a complaint lodged by a Muslim that he was spreading communal animosity, the police arrested the tailor. He was released on bail two days later. The incident became a talking point in the locality, and he began to receive threats because of which he didn't open his shop for six days. When a video surfaced calling for his beheading, he approached the police with a written complaint and asked for protection. The police called a few people from the Muslim community and tried to pacify both sides, following which he reopened his shop a few days later. The fact that someone who had sought protection ended up being killed in such a chilling manner suggests that the police did not take the threats seriously enough.

In the video, the accused had also threatened to kill PM Narendra Modi which had the Centre immediately rushing a team of the National Investigation Agency (NIA) to the state even before the case was formally handed over to the central agency. Sources say the urgency was also because of reports that one of the accused could have been in touch with some people arrested with explosives by the Anti-Terrorist Squad (ATS) of Rajasthan and Madhya Pradesh Police during operations in Chittorgarh, Neemach, Ratlam and Tonk in March and April. M.L. Lather, Director General of Police, Rajasthan, claimed at a press conference on June 29 that Gaus has links with the Karachi-based Islamist organisation Dawaat-e-Islami and had visited Karachi in 2014. "They (Riyaz and Gaus) are highly radicalised and we are investigating who they have been in touch with," Lather told INDIA TODAY. Besides the two prime accused, three more persons have been arrested so far.

In an immediate reaction to the killing, CM Ashok Gehlot said such a gruesome act could not have been carried out without some organisation in or outside India instigating the accused. Officials say they have been scanning the mobile phones of the accused and searching their homes for possible links with radical groups like the



THE SLAIN
Kanhaiya Lal, a Udaipur-based tailor, was hacked to death in his shop

Popular Front of India (PFI) here, and also Dawaat-e-Islami, Muslim Brotherhood and even ISIS.

Kanhaiya Lal's killing has led to apprehensions about terror modules operating in Rajasthan, which has seen terrorist strikes in the past, including the 2008 serial bombings in Jaipur that left 71 dead and more than 200 injured. Moreover, communal incidents in recent years indicate a growing polarisation on religious lines. Though Muslims have widely condemned Kanhaiya Lal's killing, Gehlot and his administration are worried that the incident could trigger communal violence against the minority community. The chief minister rushed top police officers and additional troops to Udaipur. Curfew was imposed in parts of the city and internet suspended across the state to minimise the chances of riots breaking out. On their part, the BJP and right-wing groups have announced bandhs and are holding rallies to protest the killing of the tailor, who was cremated on June 29 in the presence of high-ranking officers.

Investigation agencies suspect a wider involvement of terror groups in the killing of Kanhaiya Lal

The two prime accused have been living in Udaipur for many years. Riyaz had shifted here from Asindh, a town in Bhilwara district, two decades ago. Asindh was in the news in 2001 when a few hundred people from the Gurjar community demolished a mosque and placed a Hanuman idol on a marble platform erected at the site. Those who supported the demolition claimed it was not really a mosque.

Riyaz and Gaus were fleeing on a motorcycle when they were caught from Rajsamand, some 60 km from Udaipur. In December 2017, it was in Rajsamand that Shambhu Lal Regar had uploaded a video of himself hacking and burning to death Mohammad Afrazul, a 48-year-old labourer who had migrated from Malda, West Bengal. Gehlot's detractors accuse him of Muslim appeasement, saying the police and the administration treat violence by Muslims as a reaction to injustices done to the community elsewhere.

Following Kanhaiya Lal's killing, Gehlot asked PM Modi and Union home minister Amit Shah to address the nation on the growing communal rift in the country. While the CM expects Modi and Shah to rein in Hindu fanatics, the BJP accuses him of encouraging violence by Muslims. Calling the Udaipur killing a "terror attack", BJP spokesperson and MP Rajyavardhan Singh Rathore has accused the Gehlot government of "directly or indirectly" promoting extremist groups.

Gehlot holds the home portfolio too and his rivals in the party and the BJP have long demanded that he must have a full-time home minister. The fallout of Kanhaiya Lal's killing may force the Congress high command to make him appoint a veteran like Shanti Dhariwal, who had been home minister earlier, to the post. Gehlot is adept at deflecting criticism away from himself but, with the state going to polls next year, perhaps it's time for him to assess whether shifting blame to Modi-Shah for his failures has disappointed even his voters. ■